Episode 5 · Finale

The Sunken Sanctuary

ប្រាសាទលិចទឹក

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Phnom Kulen and its hidden temple catacombs, Siem Reap Province
Night	Night 7 · 2:30 AM – sunrise (about 6:00 AM)
Playtime	2 – 2.5 hours
Seal	#5 · The Golden Inscription Slab
Version	3.1 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

On the seventh night, Sora climbs Phnom Kulen to the guardian's ancient seat. Four trials beneath the mountain each end in a memory of one generation the debt has taken. At the altar, with the guardian towering over her, she performs the Ritual of Severance and decides what to do with the cousin who wanted her to pay.

LOCATION	NIGHT	PLAYTIME
Phnom Kulen	**Night 7 of 7**	**2 – 2.5 hours**
Mountain path and catacombs	The debt falls due at dawn	3 acts + three endings

CORE MECHANIC	THREAT	SEAL
Trials and ritual	**Neak Ta Guardian**	**#5 Golden Inscription Slab**
Hub, four trials, boss ritual	Fully manifested	The contract itself

1.1 Episode goal

Place the four seal remnants on their shrines, open the Sanctum of the Banyan Tree and complete the **Ritual of Severance** on the Golden Inscription Slab before sunrise.

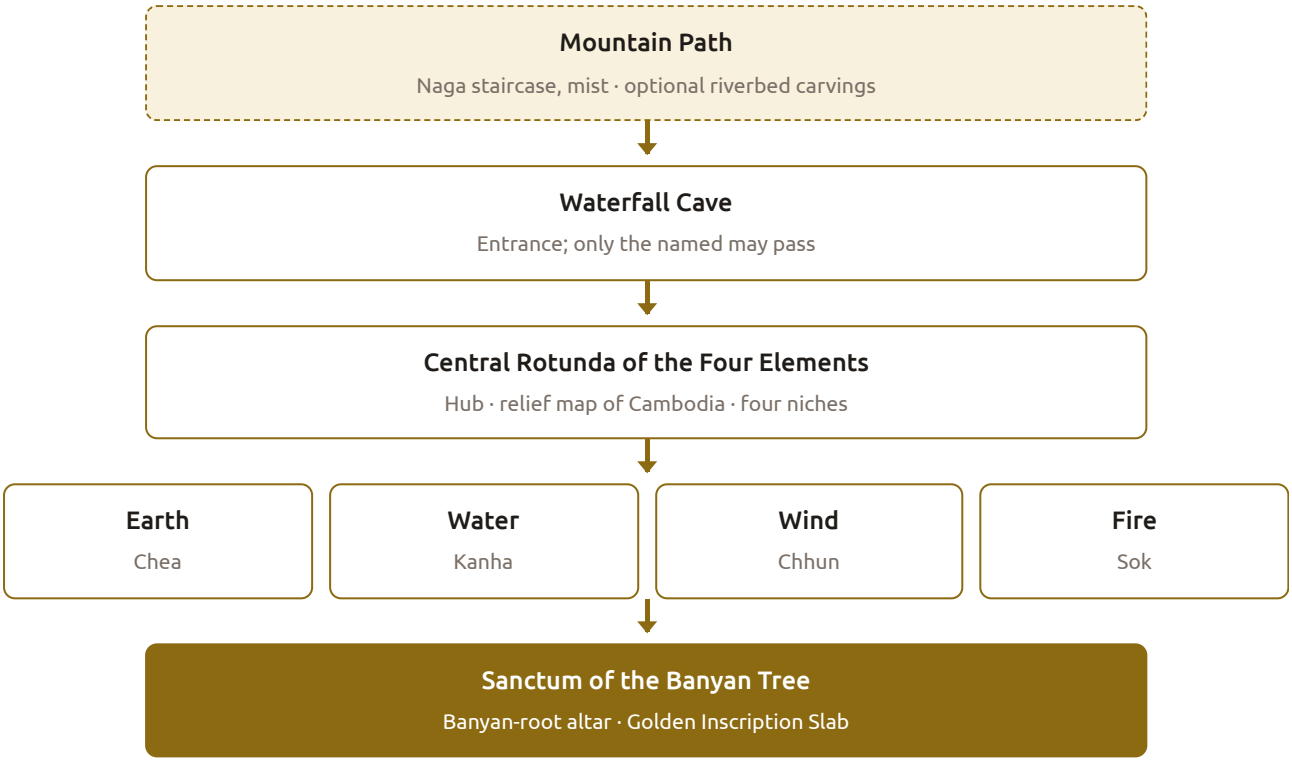
1.2 Content at a glance

Puzzles (6)	Remnant placement · Earth trial · Water trial · Wind trial · Fire trial · the chants
Threat encounters	Each trial grows harder as the guardian strengthens, followed by the three-phase boss ritual
Optional area	The riverbed carvings on the mountain path (lore notes that teach chant lines)
Key choice	Forgive Vuthy and share the offering, or refuse him
Endings	The Unbroken Freedom · The Last Payment · Bound to the Soil

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស៊ូរ៉ា	Protagonist	Exhausted and changed: no longer running from her family's past but carrying it.	Player character.
The Neak Ta Guardian អ្នកតា	Final antagonist	The guardian fully manifested: a towering multi-armed being of shadow and ancient stone in a glowing, distorted brass mask. It bends space and light to protect its contract, but it is a judge, not a monster.	Boss of the severance ritual.
Pich ពេជ្រ	Helper spirit	In the Water trial, a child's footsteps lead Sora to the first mirror, the memory of the brother she never met. If Kanha was freed, he appears again in the true ending, holding her hand.	Optional guidance; never a threat.
Ancestral memories Chea · Chhun · Kanha · Sok	Guides and testers	Each trial ends with a memory of one person the debt has claimed.	Story beats and hints.
Vuthy វុទ្ធី	Cousin	*If saved:* climbs with Sora and waits at the waterfall; only the named may enter. *If not saved:* follows her in silence, marked by the guardian.	Appears at the altar for the final choice.

03 Locations and Layout



Area	Description and key props	Gameplay use
Mountain Path	A steep sandstone staircase carved into the jungle cliff, flanked by seven-headed Naga balustrades; boundary stones (สีมา), stone braziers, banyan roots. A side path follows a stream whose bed is carved with ancient figures.	Ascent; optional lore
Riverbed Carvings · optional	Ancient carvings beneath shallow running water, lit by Sora's lamp. Some carved verses match the funeral chants.	Lore notes with chant lines
Central Rotunda	A vast circular sandstone chamber; a stone relief map of Cambodia; an altar with four empty niches; four monumental archways.	Hub; remnant placement
Earth · Chamber of Roots	A labyrinth of huge banyan roots (ជ្រៃ) through the stone, with weathered statues among them.	Sight trial
Water · Chamber of Reflections	Spring-fed stone basins and Apsara (អប្សរា) reliefs.	Mirror trial
Wind · Chamber of Whispers	A narrow corridor and a stone bridge over a chasm; wind through stone lattices; Pali inscriptions.	Sound trial
Fire · Chamber of Flames	Rows of iron oil braziers and stone incense altars.	Resource trial

Area	Description and key props	Gameplay use
Sanctum of the Banyan Tree	A circular sanctum with an open dome to the night sky; an ancient banyan whose roots wrap a linga and yoni altar holding the Golden Inscription Slab; four corner pillars.	Boss ritual; endings

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Act I · The Mountain and the Four Gateways

Playtime 0:00 – 0:30 · 2:30 – 3:30 AM

Sora climbs the Naga staircase of Phnom Kulen (ភ្នំគូលេន) through tropical mist, following the ingot's pull. If Vuthy was saved, he climbs beside her, and at the waterfall he stops: an unseen force will not let him pass. "Only the named," Sora says. If he was not saved, she hears steps behind her all the way up and never sees who it is.

An optional side path follows a stream over ancient carvings, where verses in the stone match the funeral chants (section 6). Behind the waterfall lies the Central Rotunda. Sora places each remnant in its niche:

Shrine	Remnant	Why
Fire	Bronze Token fragment (Ep 1)	Burned in the incense fire
Wind	Silver Betel Box inlay (Ep 2)	Returned at the bell, under the whispering stupas
Water	Terracotta Jar soil (Ep 3)	Purified over the lake
Earth	Molten iron ingot (Ep 4)	Melted above the shrine stone

Act II · The Four Generations

Playtime 0:30 – 1:30 · 3:30 – 5:00 AM

The trials can be played in any order. Each tests a skill from an earlier episode and ends with a memory of one generation of the debt.

Trial	Skill	Challenge	Memory
Earth	Sight (Ep 1)	A banyan-root maze where stone statues, moved by the guardian (rule 16), shift only when unwatched. Use the shutter and camera to freeze them.	**Chea**, 1910: walking home with the earth-filled box, already afraid of what he has done.
Water	Reflection (Ep 2)	Rotate bronze mirrors to strike three crystals in an Apsara relief and drain the basin. As each crystal lights, the carved Apsara dancers move for a few seconds in a slow, graceful dance: a moment of beauty, never a threat.	**Kanha**, 1920: singing to Sora as a child. If freed in Ep 3, her voice hints where to aim; if not, her sorrow ripples the water and distorts the beams.
Wind	Sound (Ep 2)	Cross a stone bridge, moving only while gusts mask footsteps; Pret listen in the silences.	**Chhun**, 1911: Yay Mey's young husband, at peace with going if it spares his child.

Trial	Skill	Challenge	Memory
Fire	Resources (Ep 1)	Light braziers in a geometric order with the last matches and oil while dodging fire traps.	**Sok**, Night 1: burning the token, knowing it will kill him. "Forgive me, Sora. Or don't. But finish it."

Act III · The Ritual of Severance

Playtime 1:30 – 2:15 · 5:00 AM – sunrise

With four shrines lit, the rotunda's stone doors open onto the Sanctum of the Banyan Tree. On the altar lies the **Golden Inscription Slab**, the contract of 1910, with four names, three of them faded. The fourth reads **Sora**, with the ghost of another name scraped out beneath it.

The ground trembles and the Neak Ta Guardian rises over the altar. Sora cannot fight it. She must perform the Ritual of Severance while it attacks (section 6). As the final phase begins, Vuthy is there: with all four shrines lit, the sanctum has opened to the whole bloodline.

05 Threat Escalation

Because the trials can be played in any order, escalation is tied to **how many are complete**, not which.

Trials complete	What changes
0 (first trial)	Each trial at its base difficulty.
1	The guardian's presence enters the rotunda; the hub is no longer safe to linger in.
2	Trials gain an extra hazard: more statues, one more Pret, faster fire traps, extra ripples.
3	The light falters: oil drains faster and braziers gutter.
4 → Sanctum	The full manifestation and the three-phase ritual.

06 The Ritual of Severance

Phase	Player actions	Pressure
1 · The Four Corners	Run to the four corner pillars; tie the blessed thread (from Ep 2) around each; light sanctified incense at each.	Area attacks and tendrils between pillars.
2 · The Chants	At the altar, choose each verse of the counter-mantra from lines written in the sketchbook. Lore notes from every episode reveal which lines are true; without them, some choices are guesses.	Each wrong verse causes shadow damage and counts as a chant error.
3 · The Offering	Prick a finger with the brass pin, mix the blood with ink from her fountain pen, and redraw her own name on the slab with her own hand. Vuthy steps forward (section 7).	The final choice.

SHADOW DAMAGE

There is no health bar. The screen darkens, sound distorts and Sora's breathing grows ragged. After two or three hits (*target*) the phase restarts from its checkpoint. Chant errors are counted even when the phase restarts.

HOW LORE UNLOCKS THE CHANTS

The counter-mantra has six verses. For each, the sketchbook offers three candidate lines copied from different sources. Lore notes across the series (journal pages, Chea's confession, the clinic records, the overseer's notes, the riverbed carvings) confirm which line is genuine. A player who found most of the notes can complete the chants with certainty; one who found few must guess.

07 Endings

7.1 The final choice

FORGIVE HIM

Sora holds out her hand. Vuthy adds his blood to the ink, and Sora writes both their names on the slab together. The debt was written on the whole bloodline; two of its last generation now answer it together.

REFUSE HIM

Sora turns away and draws her name alone. Vuthy stands at the edge of the light, the guardian's shadow falling over him.

7.2 Conditions

Ending	Requires
Bound to the Soil	Three or more chant errors (*target*). Checked first.
The Unbroken Freedom	Fewer than three chant errors *and* respect of 6 or more out of 9 *and* Vuthy saved in Episode 4 *and* forgiven here.
The Last Payment	Fewer than three chant errors, but any true-ending condition unmet.

Respect sources (9 total)	Episode
Betel tray correct first time · incense never fully out	1 (+2)
No offerings wasted · honest memory · names in order at dawn	2 (+3)
Mother freed	3 (+2)
No taboo broken in the grid · every boundary stone honoured	4 (+2)

7.3 Outcomes

TRUE ENDING · THE UNBROKEN FREEDOM

As the last stroke of their two names dries, every name on the slab burns away. Golden light pours from the banyan. The guardian lowers its arms, bows its masked head and dissolves into drifting dust. If Kanha was freed, Sora glimpses her in the light for a moment, holding a small child by the hand. Through the open dome, the sky turns gold. Sora and Vuthy walk out into the sunrise together. In Battambang, Sok's cremation fire burns under a clear sky. The rice fields will flood and fail next season, the fortune is gone, and Yay Mey holds both grandchildren and says it was never theirs to keep.

BITTER ENDING · THE LAST PAYMENT

The slab takes Sora's drawn name, but the guardian is not satisfied: the contract is fulfilled, not severed. Its shadow falls over Vuthy and the fourth name on the slab changes back to his. He is gone when the light returns. Sora walks into the sunrise alone. The family keeps its land and money, and at Sok's cremation she stands apart, knowing what they cost.

BAD ENDING · BOUND TO THE SOIL

The counter-mantra breaks apart. The guardian rejects the severance and declares the debt unpaid. Darkness swallows the sanctum. Sora wakes inside the coffin in the funeral tent in Battambang, unable to move or speak, as her family weeps over her body on the eighth morning.

08 Mechanics Reference

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback
Hub and trials	Four trials in any order; each lit shrine raises the guardian's strength; four open the sanctum.	Runes glow on the rotunda altar.
Moving statues	Move only when unseen or in darkness; lamp light and direct view freeze them.	Grinding stone behind the player.
Wind timing	Movement is safe during gusts; moving in silence alerts the Pret.	Wind volume; lattice whistle.
Brazier order	Light braziers in the order sketched from the chamber's relief; a wrong order resets and costs matches and oil.	Flames flare or die.
Chant choices	Six verses, three candidate lines each; lore confirms the true line.	True lines glow; false ones bring shadow.

09 Items and Lore Notes

Item	Type	Use
Bronze Token fragment · Silver inlay · Jar soil · Molten ingot	Remnants	Placed on the Fire, Wind, Water and Earth shrines
Blessed white cotton thread	Ritual item	From Ep 2; tied around the four pillars
Sanctified incense, matches, oil	Consumables	Fire trial; Phase 1
Brass pin; fountain pen and ink	Ritual items	The offering; the pen is from Sora's starting kit in Episode 1
Golden Inscription Slab	Seal #5	The contract
Lore notes ×4	Optional	Riverbed carvings; each confirms chant lines

10 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Sandstone grey, moss green, glowing rune gold, amber, deep navy turning to golden dawn. Memories in warm sepia.
Post-processing	Strong bloom, light shafts through the dome, distortion during attacks, film grain.
Ambience	Underground bass, wind through lattices, dripping water, slow roneat (រនាត) phrases.
Horror cues	Sliding stone, the guardian's layered voice, roaring wind, shattering glass, chanting.
Interface	100% diegetic: chants, remnants and puzzle notes in the sketchbook.

11 Glossary, Revision Notes and Open Issues

Term	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Phnom Kulen	ភ្នំគូលេន	Sacred mountain	
Sima	សីមា	Boundary stone	
Banyan	ជ្រៃ	Banyan tree	Replaces v1 "Sprean"
Apsara	អប្សរា	Celestial dancer	
Linga / Yoni	លិង្គ / យោនី	Shaivite sacred stones	Still venerated; treat respectfully
Smot	ស្មូត	Buddhist funeral chanting	v1 spelled "Smat"

Changes in v3.0

- Playtime 2–2.5 hours. Each trial ends with an ancestor's memory; escalation is tied to trials completed; remnant-to-shrine mapping defined.
- Lore notes now unlock the true chant lines; the optional riverbed carvings added.
- Vuthy's final choice and three endings with exact conditions (replacing the undefined "key lore choices").
- The Guardian's mask is no longer called "Mukhalingi" (a mukhalinga is a carved linga, not a mask).
- **v3.1** (Story Bible): Phase 3 is now Sora redrawing her name in ink and blood (her art matters at the climax); Vuthy enters because the sanctum opens to the bloodline (rule 9).
- **v3.2**: Earth-trial statues are forms of the guardian; the Apsara carvings dance in the Water trial; Pich appears as a helper or in the true ending.

OPEN ISSUES

- The blood offering and the linga/yoni altar are sensitive; review with the cultural advisor and keep the presentation restrained.
- The riverbed carvings evoke real sacred sites near Phnom Kulen; keep the in-game version fictional and respectful.
- Name the Guardian's mask with an accurate term.
- Playtest the respect threshold (6 of 9) and the chant-error limit (3).